In addition to being Titans coach, Dave was also head coach of the national Under-19 side, a stroke of good fortune for me. I was excited, and an eager and talented squad gathered for eight days of careful preparation at the new High Performance Centre in Pretoria. We were all aware that the previous South African Under-19 team to tour England had been 'whitewashed' in 2000, and we were fiercely determined to play well.

The senior Proteas squad was also playing England and, in the very same week Graeme Smith's side were beating England at Lord's (with Graeme scoring 259 and Makhaya Ntini taking 10 wickets), we set about the task of playing the first of three unofficial Tests against the England Under-19 team at Headingley in Leeds.

Our match turned when a fast bowler from Bellville in the Cape named Vernon Philander took five for 50 in the English second innings. Chasing 228 in the fourth innings to win, we lost early wickets but Rieel de Kock and I managed to build a partnership and both scored half-centuries; we won by six wickets. He was, incidentally, the selfsame Rieel de Kock who had flattened me with the perfect tackle when playing for Grey College against Affies a year before.

England called up a young opening batsman called Alastair Cook for the second unofficial Test played at New Road, Worcester, and he made 51 in their first innings total of 523. Batting under pressure, we collapsed to 28 for four and followed on. Defeat seemed inevitable.

However, by now, a talented left-handed batsman from Cape Town was emerging as the star of our squad. His name was JP Duminy and, coming together in desperate trouble at 54 for three midway through the third day, he and I set about the task of saving the match; we concentrated, worked hard and reached stumps at 166 for three. The partnership continued on the final morning, and by the time JP was finally dismissed we had added 220 runs for the fourth wicket. The middle order and tail continued to fight through a nervous afternoon and evening, and, with